

associates were buying up the farmland of Illinois—a final triumph of theoretical agriculture over the real thing.

I tried to confirm all this with Mr. Ritchey, but he never responded to my numerous phone calls. I did get through to Thane Armstrong, his stepson, who volunteered to show me around CRT. Mr. Armstrong was a huge tight-end of a man, as good-natured as a koala, who worked summers at CRT on his breaks from college. He corroborated most of the above, beginning with Mr. Ritchey's having started out as a sheriff's deputy. He also told of Mr. Ritchey's stint as a bus driver for the Chicago Transit Authority, his great genius for math, his first success at trading silver in the early 1970s, his playing the soybeans against the soybean meal, his joining forces with friends and relatives to trade gold, then bonds, then Treasury bills, and his subsequent conquest of the various markets of the world.

CRT was rumored to be so big it bought and sold half the Treasury bonds in the Treasury-bond pit, and often did more bond-futures business than the famous Salomon Brothers or Goldman, Sachs, billions of dollars a day. Mr. Armstrong said he didn't know about that, but he took me to see one of the bond traders, who requested I not use his name. I'm allowed to mention that he wore a loud Hawaiian shirt, which served the same purpose as Mr. Hersh's orange-and-white-checkered jacket. The bond trader confirmed that he handled huge quantities of bond contracts, a big responsibility for a 27-year-old. He said he lived on a farm and drove into Chicago early every morning to get the jump on his competition. The only thing that bothered him about the job was the swearing. "I didn't used to know how to swear," he said. "I learned it in the bond pits."

Mr. Armstrong and I must have walked a half mile up and down corridors, between desks, and around computers as we talked. He told me about the family atmosphere at CRT, and that many employees were graduates of the nearby Wheaton College, a no-nonsense, God-fearing campus. It sounded as if these were young, close-knit, hard-working Jesuits of finance, making millions at a furious pace.

Though much has been made of Mr. Ritchey's alleged funda-